

2 Psychology in the Hellenic Age: From the Pre-Socratics to the Dialogues

Within an area approximating the size of Montana, and over a period of less than three hundred years, the Greek-speaking people of the ancient world would produce the philosophers Thales, Anaxagoras, Empedocles, Parmenides, Zeno, Pythagoras, Protagoras, Socrates, Plato, and Aristotle; the dramatists Aeschylus, Sophocles, Euripides, and Aristophanes; the historians Herodotus, Thucydides, and Xenophon; Hippocrates the physician; Pericles the political leader; Pheidias the sculptor; and the various schools and traditions that would become associated with these names. This span of time, a period covering roughly the appearance of the school or sect of the Pythagoreans in 530 B.C. to the flowering of Aristotle's scholarship two centuries later, comprises the Hellenic epoch of classical Greece, an epoch not anticipated by any prior age.

Having now taken the fateful step toward resurrecting this famous coterie of "dead, white, European males," as some in today's world would have it, a few words are in order concerning the nature of the debt to Hellenism in general. To begin, although the ancient Greeks were suspicious of strangers and more or less convinced of the superiority of their own culture, the leaders of thought in that age did not regard their achievements in racial or ethnic terms. It would take the unifying vision and energy of Alexander the Great to spread Hellenism throughout the conquered territories, but many of these same territories needed little by way of coercion. Moreover, the more enlightened Greeks understood Hellenism itself to be a set of values and attitudes about culture and civilization; about beauty and learning and education; about life within an ordered family and an ordered state. As Isocrates (436–338 B.C.) would express it in his *Panegyrics*, all who shared the Hellenic conception of culture (*paideia*) were "Greek" in the most relevant sense of the term. The extent to which ancient Romans came to share this conception was so considerable that Pliny would declare Rome to be a Greek city! Over the many centuries since that

time, something of a unifying and common culture has been adopted and developed by the peoples of England, Europe, and their major settlements. This culture, too, has been so utterly indebted to Hellenism that Anglo-European civilization might also be termed "Greek," at least at its core.

The attention routinely directed to the ancient Greek world by students of nearly every academic subject is to be understood, therefore, not as a species of Western jingoism, but as the necessary means of identifying the sources of a profoundly influential intellectual tradition. Only through such inquiries does it become possible to fathom how a set of culturally transmitted patterns of thought can be developed and rearranged to yield the well-known achievements and limitations of civilizations in the post-classical period. Roman civilization itself, the very template for so much that would unfold in European history, was self-consciously "Hellenic" in many of its most defining features. To this day, the preoccupations of scientists, scholars, and intellectuals of every stripe are bequests of Hellenic civilization, including the very preoccupations that would find such fault with that civilization.

Nonetheless, an inquiry into Hellenism should not be understood as provincially "Western." Hellenic and Hellenistic influences reached beyond Rome and across great expanses of time and space, extending to and beyond the Indian subcontinent. The influences were fully discernible in art, in philosophy, and in the general culture long after the last vestiges of Alexandrian or Roman military power had receded from the near-eastern world. Hellenistic decorative arts, for example, remained the choice of affluent near-east Asian well into the fourth century A.D. In a word, there is nothing regional about Hellenic civilization except its birth, and, of that part of it that has endured into modern times, there is surprisingly little that is derivative. For the historian, therefore, and especially the historian of ideas, an understanding of that particular civilization must be a central project, and one without any alternatives of equal consequence. At the very core of this central project is the appearance of philosophy and the immense range of issues and subjects it would spawn. We are repaid by devoting attention to the factors that nurtured this incomparably productive civilization.

The Nurturing Conditions

Preliterate societies perpetuate themselves by developing non-literate aids to memory, such as paintings and monuments, songs and signs, poems and dances. As with so many such societies, the peoples who would emerge as the Greek-speakers of the ancient world must have used just such devices to record a settled history and to establish a stabilizing method by which to transmit customs and belief to later generations. In such a world the dance might evolve into the poem, the poem into a chorus, the chorus into drama, and the drama

into the dialogue. In the Greek world, the dramatic and poetic depictions of life's confusions and possibilities were transformed into nothing less than philosophy itself. The foundations can be seen in those eighth-century epics of Homer that would shape Greek thought and imagination for centuries.

In the *Iliad* and the *Odyssey*, Homer presents what is already a developed conception of human nature and the determinants of the human condition. We find heroic undertakings explained in terms of specific emotions arising within and taking control of regions of the body (heart, chest, abdomen), and still other behavior ascribed to the gods who can send demons to disturb sleep or shape dreams or impersonate mortals. What is so vividly developed in these epic poems is the need to understand oneself, to externalize our thoughts and images and passions in such a way as to examine them in nearly clinical fashion. Also emblematic in these works is at once the tentativeness and the sheer multiplicity of explanations. There is no pretention to certainty or infallibility, no last word. Consider only Homer's treatment of the causes of the war with Troy. Was it the result of Helen's indiscretion? Was it caused by Paris, who chose Aphrodite over her competitors for the prize reserved to the "most beautiful," or was the cause the offense given Discordia by not inviting her to the feast in the first place? Was it the intemperate anger of the dishonored Hellenes seeking revenge at all costs? Was it the personal character of such men as Agamemnon and his brother, Menelaus, husband of Helen—a character seen in their father, Atreus, whose own rapacious actions had been at the expense of innocent others? In verse after verse, the audience discovers the complex chain of events that might unfold from the simplest and most innocent of beginnings; the manner in which our most thoroughly considered courses of action can be upset by chance or divine intervention.

In the end, the epics point to the importance of an ordered state, to the need for reasonable methods for settling disputes, to the necessity of character and fortitude in all we do. And though due consideration is paid to the gods and to the fates, Homer's explanations of human conduct are typically naturalistic, even biological. One acts owing to impulses arising in the body. One dies when vital organs are damaged. After death there is some shadowy but (except in rarest instances) mindless residual, briefly revived by the fresh blood of animals, but soon to revert to a wraith-like existence utterly removed from the human condition. True immortality is possessed only by the gods, and this owing to a special substance, *ichor*, which runs in their veins. They are otherwise distinguishable from mortals by their extraordinary but not total power over natural events, and by their strength, their cunning, and their craftsmanship.

The gods of Homer have their favorites among mortals and even occasionally breed with them, but in general the Olympians are preoccupied with their own affairs, often indifferent and even contemptuous of human lives and limitations. Thus they must be propitiated, never aroused to anger or envy. But they

are also not looked to for answers to the abiding questions or for solutions to the problems of life and mind. In the matter of fundamental truths and their implications, we are left to our own devices, for, in these matters, the gods themselves are limited. Even mighty Zeus must consult the fates if he would know the end result of his designs. In these and related respects, Homer's immense contribution to the emerging culture of Hellenism was pre-philosophical but utterly compatible with an essentially philosophical outlook.

There is no question but that the intellectual tone and background of Greek life from the seventh to the fourth centuries derived inspiration from these works. But Homer's was not the only literary influence. Supplementing it were works by Hesiod slightly later in the same century. His *Works and Days* records the life of the modest farmer working with nature, within the cycles of the seasons, developing an ethics based upon the orderly and productive works of a properly tended and respected earth. The point of *Works and Days* is not merely a summary of the agrarian life, but a praise of its social and ethical character. Together, the Homeric and Hesiodic perspectives would impose on Greek thought a conservative and measured quality, a worldview that would locate human life within the larger framework occupied by all living things, by the elements, by the gods. When Achilles finally overcomes his indignation and prepares to avenge the death of his dear friend Patroclus, he urges his horses to their duty, and he hears from one of them that they will not let him down. If speech is a gift of the gods, who is to say on whom or what they will confer it? Human life and our special powers, on this view, are not above nature but inextricably bound up with it. Centuries later Aristotle will insist that the political state, the *polis*, is an entirely natural entity proper for a kind of animal that is social by nature. In this he reaches a philosophical position entirely at one with Homer's.

The Greeks honored the Olympians and believed in the prophetic power of oracles, but they did not have the equivalent of a "prophet" as this type was known in the eastern world, nor did they claim to possess a body of divine and unchallengeable truths. Epic poetry was rich enough in metaphor to serve as a daily guide to a life. Unlike their Jewish contemporaries or their Christian successors, the Greeks of the ancient world did not possess revealed truths or a code of undisputed moral precepts. The codes by which they lived had for them the authority of history and the additional authority of nature: To live in accordance with the model of nature was to be true to one's own nature, for the latter was but a part of the former.

The effects of this were at once positive and negative. On the positive side, the absence of such revelation permitted a freedom of interpretation and a creative approach to the spiritual dimensions of life. This surely had a subtle but pervasive part in the evolution of philosophy, nurturing an inquiring and even skeptical mind.

On the negative side, the absence of a codified body of religious principles

not only compounded the ever greater problem of political unity of the Greek people but also encouraged an assortment of superstitious beliefs within various communities. Even as the classical achievement was becoming part of the historical record, the masses of Greek people remained quite committed to notions of witchcraft, prognostication, omens, and curses. That the better minds of the period had only contempt for all this is evident in Plato's rebukes found in the *Republic* (Book II, 364) and in *Laws* (Book X, 909b; XI, 933a). Nevertheless, in this (as in so many other ways) the philosophers were outside the common culture.

There is another side to this story that warrants brief mention. It has often been observed that, if the Greek world did not have an official and codified religion, it also never was a totally secular state. What the period we call "classical" displays, in such a great variety of ways, is integration: the integration of the religious, the political, the moral, and the aesthetic. Where strict religious orthodoxy does come into play, it is often aroused by philosophical challenges. In the main, however, the ancient Greeks grounded their convictions quite broadly, with religion and ethics, and family life and the good of the polis being interchangeable conceptions, interdependent features of life. Accordingly, the religious tone of sixth-century Greece was neither speculative nor personal. Rather, it was civic.¹ Philosophy, when it did appear, was less a threat to than an expression of a reverential and naturalistic theology already in place for centuries.

Philosophy: The Ionian Invention

The situation of the seventh-century Ionians was unique in the Greek world. Their settlement of the Aegean islands and coastal cities of Asia Minor was prompted initially by scarcity on the mainland and by attractive trading prospects. Their native homeland was for the most part Attica, meaning that Athens was their mother city. If the history of immigrant experiences in modern times is applicable, we can conjecture that they displayed that same "pride of race" witnessed among displaced citizens the world over. Fear of assimilation seems to be an abiding condition of wandering people. That the earliest Homeric scholars should appear in Ionia is, therefore, in keeping with this tradition. The further one removes oneself from the culture of one's childhood, the more strenuously one asserts its virtues and protects its uniqueness. The Ionians of the seventh century were quite possibly more "Greek" than their Athenian cousins.

Given the general cultural background, the Ionian Greeks were further inclined toward philosophy by daily contact with radically different cultures based on radically different concepts and traditions. Commerce introduced them to foreign goods and foreign beliefs. Their relations with Egypt were

surely the source of their later development of monumental architecture and may well have conveyed certain religious doctrines that the philosophically minded Greeks would transform in a speculative science. It is not surprising, then, that the Ionian colonies and those established in Italy would yield such inventive philosophical pioneers: Thales, Anaximander, and Anaximenes were from Miletus; Heraclitus from Ephesus; Anaxagoras from Clazomenae; Pythagoras from Samos; and Xenophanes from Colophon. In the Italian reaches of the Ionian influence, we record Philolaus from Tarentum, Empedocles from Acragas, and Zeno and Parmenides from Elea. Then north of the Ionian cities, in Thrace and the centers along the Black Sea, the names of Protagoras, Democritus, and Leucippus are added. These are the figures who outlined the issues with which Plato and Aristotle would contend and which have caught the imagination and frustrated the minds of scholars for two millennia. The movement would culminate in Athens, which we learn on the authority of Athena herself is the place the gods would choose to live above all others save for Olympus.

Pre-Socratic Psychology

It is especially important when ^{testing} assaying the outlook and contribution of the pre-Socratics to keep two considerations in mind. First, we have very few of their writings (of those who actually did have their thoughts recorded), and, second, many of the later commentators on whom we must rely are far from unimpeachable. If Thales or Pythagoras ever set thought to papyrus, all evidence is lacking. What survives of Anaximander's scholarship is some five sentences; and only one remains by Anaximenes. We have nearly 140 fragments of Heraclitus, of which perhaps several dozen require serious attention. We are more fortunate where Empedocles and Democritus are concerned, less fortunate in the case of Protagoras. All told, the major figures of the pre-Socratic achievement can be investigated directly through fewer than two hundred pages of modern text. Indirect evidence, however, suggests that the group was responsible for perhaps as many entire books. Liberally, then, we may lay claim perhaps to one percent of their contributions.² The balance of what we know of them must be reconstructed from what later philosophers said of them, often in the context of severe criticism developed in conjunction with attempts to fashion opposing systems. It will be sufficient in the present context to consider the pre-Socratics only to the extent that they set part of the agenda for the psychological theories and studies of the Socratic and later schools.

Cosmocentric-Anthropocentric

It is often said (and was said by Socrates and other ancient commentators themselves) that Socrates, unlike his predecessors, directed philosophical inquiry

away from the heavens and toward human concerns: that he shifted attention from cosmos to anthropos. Although it is undeniable that the richly developed psychological theories passed down by Plato are without precedent, they are not utterly divorced from an earlier philosophical tradition. That earlier tradition, with debts to far older and Eastern mythologies, focused on the created cosmos, the source of all that exists, the elementary composites out of which ever more complex entities come into being. This earlier tradition is exemplified in the teachings of Pythagoras and of Parmenides. Brief consideration of their philosophies conveys a sense of the issues and methods bequeathed to the Socratics. But even before this, it is worth noting some of the pressures that might have inclined Socrates and his circle away from cosmological matters. The reasons are not purely intellectual.

Protagoras and Anaxagoras, among the pre-Socratic philosophers, had both suffered the wrath of orthodox Athenian society by investigating the secrets of the heavens. The ordinary Athenians were willing to tolerate philosophical speculation as long as things were going well, but once the political or financial or military fortunes of the city were in jeopardy, they were quick to find scapegoats. Thus, that the Fragments of the pre-Socratics are often ambiguous, that the Pythagoreans were committed to keeping their wisdom private, and that the Age of Pericles itself was rife with censorship offer proof enough that the Hellenic epoch was never really tolerant, or, if tolerant, was never completely nurturing of speculation.

A passage from Plutarch's *Lives* drawn from the biography of Nicias is suggestive here:

People would not then tolerate natural philosophers, and theorists, as they called them, about [the laws of the heavens]; as lessening the divine powers by explaining away its agency. . . . Hence it was that Protagoras was banished and Anaxagoras cast in prison . . . and Socrates, though he had no concern whatever with this sort of learning, yet was put to death. . . . It was only afterwards that the reputation of Plato . . . because he subjected natural necessity to divine and more excellent principles . . . obtained for these studies currency among all people.³

The interests of the pre-Socratics arose from the most basic issues and problems. In general terms, the issues that attracted their attention were metaphysical, concerned with nothing less than questions of actual being. Just how is it that anything exists, and what is the source of such existence? It will be instructive to review even hastily how Pythagoras and Parmenides approached questions of this sort.

At the risk of putting words into the mouth of a philosopher whose entire sect was sworn to public silence, one might still speculate with some confi-

dence that Pythagoras was inspired initially by the marked relationship between mathematical abstractions and actually existent and observable events and things. The most well-known of these relationships is the Pythagorean theorem which at once is an abstract axiom of plane geometry and, at the same time, a relationship obtaining among all actual rectilinear triangles.

An even more subtle form of the relationship is found in music, especially the relationship between number and music. Pythagoras is credited with the theory of musical harmony, but he was clearly interested less in this than in the larger implications arising from it. If, in fact, the full range of musical perceptions experienced as harmonious is generated by notes that stand in strict numerical relationships, it follows that other—even all—aspects of observable nature have a similar origin. Taking the first four integers (the tetractys) 1, 2, 3, and 4 as primal, Pythagorean teaching proposed that the first corresponded to the point, the second to the line, the third to the plane and the fourth to the solid. The four integers as abstractions are somehow generative of a world of solid objects. This is achieved by means that cannot be physical for the physical world is produced by such means. Thus, it must be in the realm of soul that abstract numbers are, as it were, absorbed and used to produce the material world. A similar line of reasoning then would confer similar constructive powers on the souls temporarily embodied in living persons; not that the mental or spiritual side of human nature actually creates the physical world, but that the changeable and imperfect objects of nature become understood in terms of abstract conceptions possessed by the soul. This tension between the abstract and the objective, the ideal and the "real," the spiritual and the material will be confronted time and again in the history of psychology and centrally in the philosophical psychology of Plato.

We next consider Parmenides of Elea (b. 515 B.C.?) as illustrative of the most original thinking of the period, though here again the available record is fragmentary and amenable to a variety of interpretations. Choosing to express his theories in poetic form, Parmenides set forth his philosophy in a work that may originally have been titled "On Nature," in which he critically examines various paths to truth.

The function of critic in the poem is taken by a goddess who leads Parmenides toward truth by way of a dialectical method. The most important conclusions Parmenides reaches through close analysis are that whatever has real being—whatever really is—must be eternal and unchanging, and that such real existence can never be discovered by the senses. The thesis seems to rest on the claims that it is contradictory to attribute existence to that which is never the same at different times, and that it is incoherent to argue that any existing thing came into being from nothingness. If, in fact, it were the case, as Heraclitus insisted, that one can never descend into the same river twice (i.e., that everything is everywhere in a state of constant flux), then we could not say that

Senses never show same thing
Zeno's.

anything actually exists, for whatever we would put forth as a candidate would be changing even as we referred to it. It would, in a manner of speaking, be gone before it was noticed. But then we would have to conclude that all that does exist came from that very non-thing whose nonexistence is guaranteed by its continuous change. To escape the bind is first to reject the sensible realm as the realm of real being, for only the sensibles display such inconstancy. What is left, absent the removed sensibles, is a realm of abstractions, stable and eternal truths accessible if at all only to reason.

Plato's debts to this line of reasoning, too, will become obvious later in this chapter. It is sufficient here to note Parmenides, along with Pythagoras, Anaxagoras, Heraclitus, Anaximander, and others as the founders of a new intellectual movement appearing in the Greek world of the sixth and late fifth centuries B.C. Their teachings would come to be the subject of painstaking dissection and study by the Socratics and later by Aristotle. Throughout this development the most general issue would remain that of "real being." In its original Parmenidean (Eleatic) form it was an issue tied to an implicit theory of human psychology. The theory, which would be defended later by Plato, is that the human senses are confined to the realm of appearances, whereas what is true occupies a realm beyond the senses.

Although their teachings and even their methods of philosophizing differed, the pre-Socratic philosophers at large shared a set of common concerns that might be economically reduced to four, the same four that have guided speculation ever since. In the broadest sense of the terms these are theology, physics, ethics, and psychology. The philosopher's mission was understood as the discovery of those unifying principles that would illuminate and solve the many different problems associated with these four areas of concern. In the dialogues of Plato, there is a sustained attempt to integrate all four areas into the most general of theories regarding not only real being, but the very point of existence itself, including and especially human existence.

Plato's Psychology

The circle of philosophers forming around Socrates (469–399 B.C.) initiated discussions of the most fundamental nature and thus set in motion much of what would come to be the subsequent history of philosophy. The group was assembled in the wake of a devastating war which Athens lost to Sparta. The philosophers associated with Socrates were, it must be recalled, on the losing side of that war. It is not surprising that so much of their attention would be given over to questions of ethics, politics, and the virtuous life. Had there been no social pressures working against cosmological speculation, recent history alone would have inclined such active minds toward these humanistic subjects.

It is after the second and decisive Peloponnesian War (431–404) that we

find these young and not so young Athenian intellectuals searching for the point at which things took a wrong turn; a turn away from the (glorified?) humanism of the Age of Pericles. Most of what is known of their concerns reaches us through dialogues composed by Plato who founded the famous Academy and composed his works years after Socrates' death. But, as with the Evening Star and Morning Star, the identities of Socrates and Plato dissolve into one another when either is observed long enough.

Socrates was the master, and by his own admission a "gadfly" flitting through the markets and assemblies of Athens and pricking the conscience of the complacent. It is likely that Plato not only knew him in childhood but that he was introduced to many members of the Socratic circle. Except for neighborly comments offered a generation later by Xenophon, our only record of Socrates' life and ideas is that recorded by Plato in the monumental dialogues. It is by no means certain, however, that Plato served as a loyal student in this regard, whatever he claims for himself in his Second Epistle:

[T]here is not and never will be a work of Plato; the works which now go by that name belong to Socrates, embellished and rejuvenated.⁴

Much in the dialogues must be Plato's own invention, as much certainly establishes quite basic changes in perspective from the earliest to the latest dates. Accordingly, the inescapable generalizations we seek in the dialogues are, when found, unavoidably arguable. What is clear is that the failures of the state, the moral decline so evident in the wake of the Age of Pericles, help to account for the conservative tone of the teachings and for the reluctance at least on Plato's part to become absorbed into the nonphilosophical affairs of the world. A child of wealth, groomed for leadership, Plato relates his decision to forgo any and all political options:

[O]ur city was no longer governed according to the customs and institutions of our fathers. . . . [T]he letter of the laws, and our customs were giving way to an even greater corruption and disrespect. . . . [W]hen I considered these things, seeing everything being driven helter-skelter, my head was in a whirl. . . . I realized that all existing states without exception had irremediably bad constitutions. . . . So, in praise of true philosophy, I was obliged to say that through it alone can we recognize what is right for states as well as individuals.⁵

The intellectual range of the dialogues is universal. They analyze all the problems introduced by the pre-Socratics and in the process advance others that only the Socratics seem to have conceived. We shall investigate but a narrow set of these topics, the set that pertains to matters of consequence in the history of psychology and that still survives in contemporary psychological scholarship. Broadly defined, the set contains four core problems: (1) the prob-

lem of the knowable, (2) the problem of knowledge, (3) the problem of conduct, and (4) the problem of governance. The first of these contains the Platonic position on the truly existing. The second considers the role and limitations of sensation, perception, and memory in relation to the knowable. The third addresses psychological and psychosocial development, the determinants of behavior, and the tension between the rational and emotional dispositions. The fourth examines the foundations of society, the family, and the moral dimensions of interpersonal life.

The Problem of Knowledge and the Knowable

Few of the dialogues are confined narrowly to a single problem. Those that are—for example, *Charmides* (temperance), *Lysis* (friendship), and *Laches* (courage)—tend to be brief, even casual. The major works are intense and far-ranging. Very nearly all of them at least touch on the problem of truth and of what can be said truthfully about anything.

In its most innocent and most ^{philosophic} vexing form, the problem of knowledge is this: How can we specify what is knowable without implicitly claiming to know it? How can we sincerely claim to search for what we have not yet identified as knowable? And even if we do identify some domain of the potentially knowable, what sources of knowledge are the most valid and which ones are likely to deceive? How, in the end, can we ever be sure that we know anything? Maybe a complete skepticism is the most philosophically defensible position (assuming such a skepticism even leaves room for a position being defensible!).

For a philosophy such as that of the Socratics, concerned with virtue, with government, and with social organization, it is obvious that these ontological and epistemological problems must be engaged. It makes no sense to inquire into the question of justice or courage or love until we have established that inquiry itself is valid and that its results are true. Thus, the initial development of a workable epistemology is indispensable to the larger Socratic mission. It is this epistemology that will distinguish the knowable from the unknowable, truth from mere opinion, reality from illusory appearance.

The position taken by the Socratics on the question of knowledge was part invention and part reaction. The reaction was to the teachings of the major Sophists. We observe this most vividly in the opening scene of the dialogue *Meno*, named after the young aristocrat recently returned to Athens from Thessaly, where the sophist Gorgias is influential. He is accompanied by a servant who proves to be the pivotal figure in the dialogue.

In something of a teasing manner, Meno tells Socrates that he would like to be able to return to Thessaly equipped to instruct his Thessalian friends in the virtuous life and, accordingly, would hope that Socrates might share the truth

with him. Socrates, ever on guard, explains that until he knows what Meno construes virtue to be, he surely could not prescribe a virtuous life. Meno, we might guess, has learned a trick or two from Gorgias and now poses a typical Sophist paradox:

And how will you enquire, Socrates, into that which you do not know? What will you put forth as the subject of enquiry? And if you find what you want, how will you ever know that this is the thing which you did not know? (80)⁶

Meno's challenge is based on the contention that all inquiry is impossible, since (1) if we are ignorant, we have no starting point for an inquiry and (2) if we are informed, no inquiry is needed. Socrates' reply takes advantage of the fact that Meno's servant is a young, uneducated "barbarian." Socrates begins to question the servant about geometric forms which Socrates draws in the sand. The boy answers a number of questions with "yes" or "no" as Socrates leads him on to a version of the Pythagorean theorem. Little by little, and not before hosting several conceptual errors, Meno's servant approaches and finally attains the understanding of the relationship between the diagonal of a square and its area. On no occasion does Socrates actually give away the answer. He merely paces him through a series of logico-mathematical steps until the insight appears. The exercise is meant to prove the first principle of Socrates' theory of knowledge, that knowledge is a reminiscence. The knower has the truth, he doesn't learn it: rather, he is able to recall it through philosophical guidance.

The centrality of this position to the entire Socratic psychology (and epistemology) cannot be overdrawn, for if we believe that knowledge is memory we will accept the dialectical method of uncovering it. Moreover, we will give to experience a place of no special importance; to reflection, a place of unparalleled importance. The dialectical method, after all, is not simply a kind of conversation. Rather, it is a careful delineation and criticism of premises, an analysis of meanings, and an assessment of implications. Through it the student is expected to learn not only what true is but why he has failed to discern this truth previously. The "learning" is, of course, but recollection.

With respect to the place of experience in the quest for knowledge, the dialogues could not be more consistent. Under the indirect influence of Pythagoras and the direct influence of Parmenides and Zeno, Socrates rejects the senses as routes to truth. We discover in the *Theaetetus* (161), as well as in the *Timaeus* (43), and again in the "Cave Allegory" of the *Republic*, that Socrates defines the dominant mission of philosophy as the rejection of the world of appearance.

To appreciate more fully the theory developed within the dialogues it is helpful to consider one influential competing perspective. The famous Sophist, Protagoras, had contended that "Man is the measure of all things," a contention

that was skeptical as to the very existence of certain knowledge. It was a thesis leading to a nearly wanton subjectivism. If human knowledge is limited to our actual and possible experiences (sensations and perceptions and memories of same), and if these are also private and unique to each individual, then not only is man generically the measure of all things, but so is each person.

It is in the *Theaetetus* that Socrates directly challenges Protagoras' maxim:

I am charmed with his doctrine, that what appears is to each one, but I wonder that he did not begin his book on Truth with a declaration that a pig or a dog-faced baboon, or some yet stranger monster which has sensation, is the measure of all things; then he might have shown a magnificent contempt for our opinion of him by informing us at the outset that while we were reverencing him like a God for his wisdom he was no better than a tadpole. . . . For if truth is only sensation, and no man can discern another's feelings better than he, or has any superior right to determine whether his opinion is true or false, but each, as we have several times repeated, is to himself the sole judge, and everything that he judges is true and right, why, my friend, should Protagoras be preferred to the place of wisdom and instruction, and deserve to be well paid, and we poor ignoramuses have to go to him, if each one is the measure of his own wisdom? (161)⁷

As the dialogue proceeds, Socrates offers examples of the weaknesses of the sensationist position. Not only do brute animals have keen senses but so, as well, does the infant. Still, these beings cannot be said to know merely because they can see. Or, examined in another way, we continue to know that which is no longer visible. If knowledge were only and always perception, knowledge would cease when the objects of perception were removed. Not only this, but our knowledge would be in constant flux because of the ever-changing world of sense.

Thus the sick Socrates, the standing Socrates, and the reclining Socrates would all be different. But those who know Socrates are, in fact, not confused by these changing appearances. Rather, the soul, and not the senses, is able to read through these changing features and discover the real, unchanging, essential Socrates, that is, the true form of Socrates that survives all change: "Then knowledge does not consist in impressions of sense, but in reasoning about them." (186)⁸

To the extent that the method of dialectical analysis can succeed or fail, the *Theaetetus* fails. Indeed, at the end, Socrates is still frustrated by his inability to establish what knowledge is as opposed to what it is not. He succeeds in distinguishing between the specific factual knowledge acquired through the senses and the more significant general principles known to the mind (185). He also notes the difference between opinion, which may be and often is false, and

knowledge which, by definition, cannot be false (188). Socrates also uses the *Theaetetus* to present his theory of memory according to which experiences are recorded as something like wax impressions. The durability of the impression depends on the frequency of the experience and the purity of the wax (191–195). The former claim is traditional associationism, while the latter is but another expression of the Socratic emphasis on the hereditary differences among people with respect to character and quality of mind. Notwithstanding the originality of these ideas, we still must judge the *Theaetetus* as incomplete in those parts of it attempting to develop a cognitive psychology. However, where it fails, the *Republic* succeeds in clarity and scope.

Plato's *Republic* is generally regarded as a foundational work in political science, which it is, but on still another account it should be read as a quite developed and systematic Psychology. Recall that in Book II, when several of those assembled (Glaucón, Thrasymachus, and Adeimantus) implore Socrates to analyze the principal features of justice and to establish how the just man is always happier than the unjust, Socrates warns them that such a task requires "very good eyes" (368). He explains his remark by invoking the metaphor of a nearsighted person who can read distant letters only when they are greatly enlarged. Thus, to examine the nature and functions of the individual, the philosopher, whose vision is also less than perfect, must enlarge the object of study. Accordingly, it is the State (the *polis*) as the enlargement of man's personal nature that must be studied if one is to have a clearer picture of human nature. By constructing the perfect State, the philosopher will necessarily comprehend those characteristics that would produce the perfected human being (Book II, 368–369).

There is a temptation, in attempting to summarize the psychological features of this dialogue, to cull a group of suggestive quotations and with them argue that Plato anticipated all modern schools of psychology, or, on the other hand, that he subscribed zealously to some narrow view of human life within an equally narrow society. We might, for example, offer those sections of Book III in which the citizens are categorized as being made of gold, silver, brass, or iron, framed so differently by the gods that some necessarily shall rule and others serve (415). Here is a passage (which, by the way, Socrates introduces as one of the convenient fictions a leader may have to foist on the people) that stands in close accord with Book V (459–460), in which prearranged marriages and controlled breeding are proposed in order to create the class of Guardians. In this Socrates is found following the practice of breeders of hunting dogs!

There is no question but that the psychological theories advanced in *Republic* are nativistic. They are based on the assumption of powerful hereditary influences in the formation of human character and intelligence. Socratic psychology, at least in the earlier dialogues, is nativistic also in locating the "true

↓
inborn



forms" within the soul prior to all experience; indeed, prior to our very birth (*Phaedo*, 73–76).⁹ But quite as many passages can be cited in which the emphasis is on education, experience, and commerce with worthy and contemplative friends. Meno's servant, surely no man of gold by Socratic standards, still reveals (recalls) his knowledge of the "true form" of the right triangle.



As Socrates himself requires an enlargement of our humanity in order to see it more clearly, we too must step back from the lines of these dialogues in order to comprehend their meaning. The *Republic* can be understood at one level by considering again the conditions surrounding its authorship. The Athens of Pericles had been vanquished by the Spartans. In the dialogue *Laws*, it is claimed that Greece survived the assaults of Persia not because Athens was victorious at Salamis and Artemisium, but because the Spartans prevailed at Marathon and Plataea (IV, 707). In the same dialogue Plato worries that maritime wars (those on which Athens rested her security) foster a form of cowardice. The Spartans, self-denying, regimented, orderly, and traditional, have become the model by the time *Republic* is composed.

We need not search the annals of Orphism or the mystery cults of Sicily to find the roots of Platonic asceticism and puritanism. In his *Seventh Epistle* and in *Laws*, Plato is unequivocal in his respect for the political order and military achievements of fifth-century Sparta. He can only struggle to achieve a reconciliation of the basic cultural and moral tension between an Athens and a Sparta: the tension between law and freedom, pragmatism and moral absolutism, fact and value, passion and reason, and power and justice. As the various institutions and actions of the ideal republic are argued into being, we witness a coterie of valiant scholars striving to find a place in the great buzz of a declining age, to find a hopeful and reasonable order in their fallen house of cards. They are no longer sure of themselves, their loyalties, or their obligations. Unlike the confident Ionians of the previous century, they seem to have been abandoned by the gods of Homer. The proverbs of Thales, and the optimism of Anaxagoras, to which in his last hours Socrates looks with longing and disappointment (*Phaedo*, 97), are seen to be too simple. And so, read in this light, the *Republic* becomes a manifesto of the discontented and disaffected who will give up on this world,

[u]ntil philosophers are kings, or the kings and princes of this world have the spirit and power of philosophy, and political greatness and wisdom meet in one, and those commoner natures who pursue either to the exclusion of the other are compelled to stand aside. (*Republic*, Book V, 473)

To describe the Socratics as discontented and disaffected is not to say they were sullen or even pessimistic. Good humor obtains even in *Phaedo*, the saddest of the dialogues. Rather, we are to recognize Socrates and his pupils as the

there's only 2 answers
black & white

Psychology in the Hellenic Age

* courage of conviction

(stand up for what
you believe in)

enlightened and reflective critics of an age, and to realize that such philosophers, in any period, will perceive themselves as unheard by, even inaudible to, "those commoner natures." As critics they observed power falling into the hands of polemicists whose only talent was the ability to tell the masses what they wanted to hear. Seeing an entire population deluded by the trappings rather than the essence of greatness, they rejected perception as a means by which knowledge might be won. Watching a world tossed in seas of change, they searched for that which never changed and called it truth. Noting the sad fate of a people moved by passion, they devoted themselves to impersonal reason and argued well enough for what came to be known as rationalism to make it the dominant philosophy until well into the seventeenth century.

Socrates
to his
pupils

The polis described by Plato is to be led and served by those possessing the virtues of temperance, courage, and justice. Their character is guaranteed by heredity and instruction. Law is blind in the received sense, and justice is swift. Population is carefully regulated, each city limited to 5040 citizens (a number defended because it can be divided evenly by every integer from 1 to 10). Plato does not mention the plague of 430, but it is likely that the recommendations against crowding derived in part from such concerns. We also detect in this emphasis upon orderly division a retrospective appreciation of Pericles' land reforms, if not a lingering attachment to Pythagorean numerology. Education is most carefully orchestrated. Those epic poems disclosing a lack of virtue among the gods are forbidden, as are works of fiction and "panharmonic" music. No wonder that Lord Russell, reflecting on this State in the 1940s, would dismiss the entire enterprise as unblushing totalitarianism.¹⁰ As with utopias ever since, Plato's republic would solve the abiding problems through the application of carefully constructed formulas and practices even if, in the end, all are threatened with death through boredom.

Plato
Person
who is
this way

London
to
Plato

We are less concerned here with Plato's utopianism than with the theory of knowledge advanced in the *Republic*. This is illustrated most clearly in the "Cave Allegory" of Book VII, where Socrates speaks of prisoners chained in a deep cavern facing a wall on which, unbeknown to them, shadowy forms are projected. From the prisoners' perspective, the shadows are real, their movements self-controlled. By good fortune, however, one of the prisoners escapes and makes his way up to the light of day. Now, for the first time, he sees reality and recognizes that all his former understandings were but illusion. Returning to share his discovery, this newly born "philosopher" is chided by those still confined below for having been blinded on his journey and for being no longer able to enjoy life in the cave.



We can now sketch the essential features of the Socratic theory of knowledge by combining the cave allegory with both the attack on Protagoras in the *Theaetetus* and the servant's lessons in *Meno*. First, true knowledge is a knowledge of the permanent principles of reality and not of changing appearances; it



Rationalism

is a knowledge conveyed not by the senses but by reason analyzing experience. For convenience, we refer to this doctrine as "rationalism," and construe it to mean that knowledge of the world is of a cognitive, rather than a perceptual nature.

All true knowledge, in this sense, is recollection. If it can be possessed, but is not received through perception, then it is not acquired but unearthed. In other words, and as demonstrated by Meno's slave, we possess the eternal truths prior to experience. They are locked within the soul and become available to consciousness only through philosophical (dialectical) training. The doctrine is a species of nativism, for it proposes that what is discovered through philosophy is what was there in the soul all along. Moreover, the theory assumes significant and innate differences among human beings such that certain minds will not be as quick as others, nor certain characters as virtuous, no matter how nurturing the environment. Rather, some will be naturally and ineliminably superior to others in intelligence and virtue. They will, properly and inevitably, lead and protect the less fortunate. This corollary of nativism is what is sometimes called elitism. Indeed, the entire program of teaching featured in Plato's Academy was designed not as a form of public instruction for the *hoi polloi*, but as accessible only to a relative handful of the best persons, the *kaloï kagathoi*. Finally, since the eternal truths do not depend on the material senses, since they are within the soul before birth and survive within the soul after death, they are truths of a nonphysical nature. They are abstract relations, ideas of a special form, and they constitute the ultimate reality of the universe. This doctrine is a version of philosophical idealism which has arrested the attention of nearly every major philosopher of the past twenty-three centuries.

What about these Platonic "ideas"? Of all the facets of Plato's writings, probably none has received closer scrutiny than the so-called theory of ideas, this despite the warning of the renowned translator of the dialogues, Benjamin Jowett, that Plato's "theory" is not clearly set forth, that it changed over the years, and that Plato himself treated it as a sort of guess.¹¹ On the authority of Jowett, then, we will not attempt to force a unified theory upon Plato, especially in light of the different philosophical positions he reaches during the time from the early to the later dialogues. But this much is clear in his dialogues and is nowhere contradicted in them: the Platonic "ideas" do not refer to facts, are not about things, and neither arise within the body proper nor die with it. In analyzing the sources of language Socrates insists that we could not invent and agree on names for things unless we shared a kind of intuitive idea of them (*Cratylus*, 389).¹² Because of their permanence, such ideas must originate in God's mind (*Timaeus*, 28),¹³ which the cleansed soul shall join after abandoning the dead body (*Phaedo*, 81).¹⁴ Unlike the attributes (e.g., goodness, justice) of things, these ideas behold the things themselves (e.g., the good, the just), which is simply another way of removing them from the arena of perception.

The Socrates we meet in the *Parmenides* shrinks back from treating all reality as nothing but idea because to do so would cause him “to fall into a bottomless pit of nonsense” (130). But in less nervous moments he “sometimes begin(s) to think that there is nothing without an idea” (130). The Socrates of the *Phaedo* has learned, as Parmenides had predicted years earlier, not to fear such bottomless pits, and he now seems quite prepared to reject all that is not idea.

From a psychological as opposed to a metaphysical point of view, we need not try to achieve coherence in the theories about so-called Platonic ideas. We need recognize only that with respect to origins, the ideas in question would have to be innate, for the truths they possess could not be conveyed by the shifting and often deceiving data of sensory experience. We might say that whereas the “commoner natures” know only what they see, philosophers see that which they know a priori.

Although the Platonic ideas are in this sense innate, the overall theory of knowledge is not static. We have already noted the attention given to education, and when we look into the specific program of education recommended for the Guardians we see that the Socratics explicitly subscribed to a stage-theory of cognitive development. The Athenian stranger who is the teacher in the *Laws* notes that virtue and vice in childhood are known to the young only as pleasure and pain (II, 653). Since children instinctively love what is pleasurable and hate what is painful, the principal task of the educator is to make sure that true virtue becomes the object of love, vice the object of hatred. Moreover, there are critical periods of development when the lessons of virtue are most effectively conveyed by music, since virtue fundamentally is a harmonious relationship between body and mind (*Laws*, II, 653–654; VII, 790–791). This aim is furthered by close contact between parent and infant, by the rhythmic rocking of the young:

[N]ursing and moving about by day and night is good for them all and . . . the younger they are the more they will need it; infants should live, if that were possible, as if they always were rocking at sea. (*Laws*, VII, 790)

The same theme is sounded in *Republic* (III, 377, 441–442). The young are out of harmony, so to speak. Reason and passion have yet to establish that unique accord that constitutes virtue. Music, dance, and other gymnastics must be employed because the very young mind is not yet able to assimilate rational principles directly. Thus, early education uses metaphor, not literal lessons. The success of education depends, of course, on the “quality of the wax” and, only under rare circumstances will the children of a lower class qualify for the life of a Guardian (*Republic*, II, 375–376). Instruction notwithstanding, heritable differences prevail and foreordain one’s receptivity to education and the life it affords.

This focus on heredity is entirely consistent with Plato's epistemology in general. Having established to his satisfaction that knowledge of principles cannot be acquired by direct perception, he must look beyond experience to find the sources of virtue. All that is left, once experience is dismissed, is heredity. Subsequent education avails itself of worthy genetic endowments absent which the education must fail. However, given the right constitution, the individual will pass through stages of receptivity culminating in that adult stage in which philosophy can make its appeals to the latent knowledge of the soul.

The ambiguity surrounding such notions might be reduced by considering the Socratic approach to a specific and essential element of knowledge, our knowledge of space. In *Timaeus* the spokesman of the same name has been given the task of lecturing on the origin of the universe and the creation of living things, including human beings. *Timaeus* raises the question of the reality of ideas (51) and proceeds to distinguish between the true opinions formed by perception and ideas beheld by the mind but neither received through nor confirmed by the senses. Having treated that which appeals to sense and that which is contemplated only by the intelligence, he moves to a third "nature," which is space,

and is apprehended without the help of sense, by a kind of spurious reason, and is hardly real; which we, beholding as in a dream, say of all existence that it must of necessity be in some place and occupy a space. (*Timaeus*, 52)

We will confront a more extensive discussion of this theory of space perception in Kant's philosophy, where the non-sensory nature of space is a central thesis. But here in an ancient dialogue we find *Timaeus* insisting that space is not an object *out there*, nor is it a mere concept in the sense of an opinion or belief. It is certainly not learned, nor is there any feature of the objects we locate in it that permits inferences about it. Quite simply, it is not an *it* but a species of *intuitive knowledge* or, in *Timaeus's* terms, a kind of spurious reason.

The properly instructed and experienced child will surely become more accurate in space perceptions, becoming, for example, more expert as an archer. Nonetheless, we would not say that instruction and experience have in any way conveyed space perception itself. It existed *a priori* as a native endowment. Experience of a world of visible objects requires such an endowment, even as it arouses capacities otherwise latent. To say, then, that the theory under consideration is nativistic, but that it also gives education a major role, is to say that rationality is in this respect like space perception. The mind is rational by nature and is in possession of intuitive truths. Philosophical study, however, is the route to these.

· Might so brief a summary as this do justice to the Platonic theory of knowl-

edge and the psychological theory contained in it? Alas, no, for there is no single theory, or any one theory that rises above debate. Disagreement is still the rule among scholars considering the very nature of the "true forms" in Plato's theory and whether the teaching of the Academy regarded them as having real existence. Moreover, although the relevant passages in all the dialogues are skeptical about perception and the world of appearances, it is also clear that Socrates and his friends were practical and realistic men who took the evidence of perception as counting for something. Perception, they reasoned, yielded knowledge of specific facts. It failed to provide knowledge of general concepts. Thus it might serve as the foundation of belief, and a given belief might even be true. But philosophical knowledge (wisdom) is not a species of opinion or belief. A doctor, for example, may believe that a patient has diabetes on the basis of certain symptoms. A mystic may believe that this same patient has diabetes on the basis of something seen in a crystal ball. If, in fact, the patient is a diabetic, we can say that both the doctor and the mystic harbor "true beliefs," but clearly their knowledge differs. On the Socratic account, philosophical knowledge differs from each of these. It is unlike the physician's in that it concerns itself not with probabilities but with certainty. And it is unlike the mystic's because it proceeds from rational first principles, the gift of *logos*.

The Problem of Conduct

[Y]ou fancy that the shepherd or neatherd fattens or tends the sheep or oxen with a view of their own good and not to the good of himself or his master . . . that the rulers of states are not studying their own advantages day and night . . . and so entirely astray are you in your ideas about the just and unjust as not even to know that . . . the just is always a loser in comparison with the unjust.

Republic, I, 343

Here is the challenge Thrasymachus lays down against Socrates' theory of the good. In nearly modern terms, Thrasymachus points out that the rich avoid taxation through wile, whereas the poor and just person sinks further into debt. The tyrant who, were he a mere citizen, would be imprisoned for his conduct, is praised for the power, wealth, leisure, and loyalty he commands. The unjust partner too gains advantage over the just. In every sphere,

injustice, when on a sufficient scale, has more strength and freedom and mastery than justice. (*Republic*, I, 344) . Plato

Later, in Book II, Glaucon resumes the attack with the legend of Gyges' ring. The story is borrowed from Lydian lore and involves Gyges (reputed to be an ancestor of Croesus), who has discovered a magic ring by which he can make

himself invisible. He soon uses it to take command of the realm by killing the king and raping the queen. He does what he pleases once he is sure that he can never be found out, and this, argues Glaucon, is precisely what anyone will do when there is no fear of punishment.

Socrates' task is not an easy one. He must prove, first, that the way things are—the way most persons might be expected to behave—is not the way they have to be or should be; and second, that the breach between what is and what ought to be is created by a failure of reason. He begins his rebuttal by likening the soul to the state. As the state contains three classes (merchants, auxiliaries, and counsellors), the soul is occupied by three principles: the rational, the appetitive, and the passionate (Book IV, 441). The virtuous person is one who has harmonized these three principles such that reason controls appetite and, as an auxiliary to reason, passion strengthens resolve (Book IV, 443). The view of reason and appetite as opposing forces is as old as the Homeric epics and as current as psychoanalytic theory. Harmony is an abiding theme in Plato's philosophy, and the *Republic* makes frequent use of musical metaphors in stressing the need for the soul's powers to be harmonized. Ancient Greek medicine employed music therapeutically, and the Spartan ephors were very careful in regulating the kind of music heard by the citizens.

Debts to Pythagoras are fairly obvious here and elsewhere as Plato undertakes an examination of the right sort of life. The goal the Pythagoreans grandly conceived was the purification of the soul. The Socratic emphasis on harmony and music was not the overworking of mere metaphor or the sign of uncritical superstition, but an integral feature of a general cosmological theory. The world of appearances on this account is the metaphor, whereas the ultimate realities are found in abstract relationships. Just as the true form of the right-angle triangle is given not by some graphic display of appearances, so the true form of man is given by a kindred (harmonic) relationship among reason, appetite, and passion.

The soul whose elements are in discord is sick and dying. The question of "happiness" in such a condition is entirely beside the point. One will not drink a potion, no matter how cool and sweet, if one knows it is lethal. The pleasure of the moment will not serve as a rational excuse for suicide, and we would judge the alternative view as one that only a crazed person could find compelling. Thus, one who drinks this potion is either mad or is ignorant of the consequences. Those like Gyges, whose reason is a slave to appetite, are simply not living a life expressive of the nature of a rational being.

Acts of injustice and wrong-doing are perpetrated by the mad or the ignorant. As was stated in the *Timaeus* (86), madness and ignorance are both diseases of the soul. To inquire, then, whether the unjust are happier than the just is as ridiculous (*Republic*, IV, 445) as asking whether the diseased are happier than the healthy. If they are, they are mad or fools or ignorant or children. We

Reason, appetite, + passion must be in harmony for person to be happy + just.

(otherwise, if ruled by appetite, do things we shouldn't)

[When become distorted by senses]

see, then, that the problem of conduct is but another side of the problem of knowledge. The unjust are those whose appetites rule their reason. Just as those limited to perceptual knowledge fail to know what they should, those driven by sensuous pleasures fail to do what they should. Moral relativism could be true only if the epistemology of Protagoras were correct, for if it were the case that each person is somehow the measure of all things, it would follow that each person's conduct would be justified on the basis of personal likes and dislikes. Meno's slave would have as much of a right to judge of triangles before instruction as after, even though his judgments would contradict each other. If Socrates must reject the epistemological relativism of Protagoras, so too must he reject the moral relativism of Thrasymachus, Glaucon, and Adeimantus, and for the same reason. The Pythagorean theorem does not rest its truth on public opinion. The laws of harmony are not subject to human desire. Both become accessible through philosophical examination, which will lead also and inexorably to a life of temperance, justice, and spiritual health. As Meno's slave needed instruction, so do all the citizens of the State. This line of argument, then, establishes the framework for the Socratic theory of governance.

The Problem of Governance

In his *History of Western Philosophy*, Bertrand Russell seeks to demythologize Plato's heroic standing:

It has always been correct to praise Plato but not to understand him. This is the common fate of great men. My object is the opposite. I wish to understand him, but to treat him with as little reverence as if he were a contemporary English or American advocate of totalitarianism.¹⁵

Russell is quite correct in following the traditional description of Plato's *Republic* as totalitarian, but he courts the same difficulties as those facing all unwavering opponents of paternalistic governments. Plato was not ignorant of the virtues of democracy. He grew up in one quite as ennobling, we may submit, as Russell's own.¹⁶ He was also well aware of how similarly the citizen's life proceeds under forms of government with merely different names. Plato's respect for Sparta and his high hopes for the tyrants of Syracuse are not plausibly reduced to a fascistic temperament. Rather, in vesting full authority in the State, Plato merely drew the obvious implications from his psychological and metaphysical theories. As the soul is driven by rational, appetitive, and passionate faculties, so too is the polis.

So how does Plato answer Lord Russell? To begin, we observe that the just man and the just State are those living under the rule of reason; those able to

control the appetites and harmonize them with the wisdom of the intellect. While men and states are born with the capacity for such harmony, the capacity is actualized only under the leadership and guidance of the philosophically enlightened. Without this guidance the pleasures and pains of the flesh, which are the only sources of control for the child, continue to dominate the life of the adult. Mere sensuous experience in this world of appearances only strengthens the body's hold on the soul, the body being the soul's prison (*desmoterion*).

The conflict between body and soul is further illustrated in Plato's *Philebus*, which includes a discussion of three different types of pleasurable and painful experiences. There are feelings of an entirely *bodily* nature such as an itch that can be soothed by scratching; there are feelings in which both body and soul participate, such as a painful hunger happily relieved by the anticipation of food; then there are the various feelings developed within the soul alone, such as longing and love (*Philebus*, 46b). In cases in which body and soul are jointly engaged, there is a strong cognitive element in the emotion, but there can be feelings of the body without this element.

The soul will be governed either by a harmony of its faculties or by the tyranny of one of them over the others. The State is similar. The question, then, is how and by whom and to what end are political communities to be organized and directed. To answer "democratically," "by the people," and "for their happiness" is to miss the entire thrust of Plato's social and philosophical analyses. There is, first of all, no conceivable state in which the will of every single citizen can be honored. Infants cannot be consulted, nor can the dumb, the mad, the criminal. Even if all were queried, we would find few decisions recommended unanimously. The possibility, therefore, of tyranny by the majority is inescapable. What benefit is there for the minority to have a voice which, though heard, is never followed? This can sow only the seeds of rebellion. Moreover, history offers little to support any prospect of "truth by majority." The same majority on whom Pericles conferred power was quick to turn on him, to accuse him of vile and venal things. Plato would recall for Lord Russell's benefit that it was with equal dispatch that the majority sentenced to death Socrates,

concerning whom I may truly say, that of all the men of his time whom I have known, he was the wisest and justest and best. (*Phaedo*, 118)

In his counsel to kings, Plato represented the interests of the multitude, and his advice, he insists, would have been the same no matter what the form of government. But he was convinced of the difference between the best interests of the people and their knowledge of it. People can be happy in their vices, their madness, their ignorance, even their servility. Contentment can be no criterion of virtue in the State or the citizen. If true happiness, which is the har-

mony of the soul leading to a life of wisdom, justice, and temperance, is to be enjoyed by the citizens, they must be led to it. It will not be found accidentally. This is the proper end of all just republics. As it can be achieved only under conditions of peace at home and with adequate defenses against quarrelsome neighbors, the rule of law and the might of armies must be unchallengeable. Only education can enlighten and only the law can compel the citizen to receive instruction. If the young are to reap the benefits of philosophical guidance, their homes and games, their adult models and leaders, must be exemplary. The child who is taught the idea of justice cannot then be turned loose in a town whose adults are driven by lust, whose poets demean virtue, whose leaders live by deception and guile. If harmony is the goal, the sources of dissonance must be removed. Some of these are genetic accidents of nature (i.e., those born with infirmities) and must be "exposed" (i.e., exposed to the elements). Regulated breeding can reduce these accidents to a minimum. By the standards of contemporary democracies, Plato's imaginary republic seems harsh indeed. Yet, even in America, there have been laws proscribing consanguinous marriages, marriages of the mentally defective, and even marriages by those with certain hereditary defects. Public education is compulsory, curricula are established by state boards, religious rites are disallowed, genetic counselling is widespread, and the abortion of "defectives" is encouraged. The list could be expanded considerably. These are the now traditional practices of a twentieth-century republican democracy more liberal than any in history. Then, too, there are laws against obscenity, libel, treason, indecent exposure, and discrimination on racial, sexual, or religious grounds. Each of these proscriptions entails the restriction of personal freedom, and some are based on explicitly paternalistic and moral foundations.

Plato would be among the first to recognize that the "totalitarianism" is not an approach restricted to any specific form of government. It is, instead, that approach which vests in any person or corporate entity the power to control the religious, aesthetic, intellectual, and moral expressions of the rest of the citizenry. Since, on this analysis, only anarchy can free the citizen of *all* such constraints, any form of government control is dictatorial at least within those regions in which that control is exercised coercively.

Under any form of government there is an explicit or implicit covenant formed between citizens and their officials, for "[a] State arises . . . out . . . of the needs of mankind; no one is self-sufficing, but all us have many wants" (*Republic*, II, 369). Plato, we see, advances a Social Contract theory of sorts and certainly recognizes the factors that initially bring people into communal affiliations. If this motivation is ignored or frustrated by any subsequent government, either the government will be replaced or the social organization will fall to pieces. Thus, his "totalitarian" regime does not ignore the implicit covenant; it seeks to expand it, to extend the range of contributions the State can

make to the life of every citizen while still remaining a State. That Plato never envisaged a State controlling every detail of daily life is clear from his discussion of early education and the later life of the well-bred citizen:

When they have made a good beginning in a play, and by the help we have given have gained the habit of good order, then this . . . will accompany them in all their actions and be a principle of growth to them. . . . Thus educated, they will invent for themselves any lesser rules which their predecessors have altogether neglected. (*Republic*, IV, 425)

That he did not recommend an unbending discriminatory code based on class is even clearer:

we never meant when we construed the State that the opposition of natures should extend to every difference but only to those differences which affected the pursuit in which the individual was engaged." (*Republic*, V, 454)

It is the problem of governance that finally requires a theory of knowledge based on eternal memories. The confrontation in the *Protagoras* makes this clear, and it is only in the *Republic* that Socrates finally extricates his argument from a web of irksome contradictions. In the earliest stages of his debate with Protagoras, Socrates succeeds in chastening the great Sophist. Representing the interests of his young friend Hippocrates, Socrates reviews the bases on which one studies with a master. If, for example, Hippocrates wished to be a sculptor, he would want to study with Pheidias. Or, if medicine were his goal, Asclepius would be the proper tutor. What is it, then, that Hippocrates would want to be were he to submit his mind to the influence of Protagoras? When Protagoras replies that Hippocrates would wish to excel in virtue, Socrates has his opening: Yes, but can virtue be taught?

Socrates' unconvincing dialogue with Protagoras is the result of a skepticism that is absent from the later *Republic*, which was composed during his middle period. In the early work, he is hoisted by his own petard, as it were, the moment he questions a pedagogical approach to virtue for, if it is not teachable, the entire philosophic movement loses its *raison d'être*. In the *Republic*, however, we discover a more developed approach to the problem. Virtue, defined as a kind of harmony within the soul, is not taught any more than one is taught to hear harmony. The capacity to recognize harmony and distinguish it from dissonance is an integral feature of the undiseased senses. However, experience with music is necessary if this native capacity is to be realized and is to become useful to the listener. Virtue is the same. Except for those "accidents of nature," every person enters the world with a soul capable of comprehending the good. Under the guidance of an enlightened community, the child's moral de-

velopment must pass successively through stages of enlightenment culminating in a love for and recognition of virtue. This notion, only touched upon in connection with space perception in the *Timaeus* and with geometry in the *Meno*, finds its fullest expression in the *Republic* and *Laws*. The philosopher is not so much a tutor or instructor as an educator, one who leads the pupil to a confrontation with the otherwise camouflaged truths of the eternal universe. The pilgrimage can begin only after a renunciation of the world of sense, only after the dialectical method has revealed the contradictions and sophistries that hitherto had passed for wisdom. Thus, in the most basic respects, the solution to the problem of governance is education (*paideia*), understood as acculturation. The character of the State and all its citizens is completely determined by the nature of this education. It cannot be optional, nor can it be administered by just anyone who happens to come along.

Hippocrates

Socrates and his disciples loom so large historically that we often neglect to note many other creative enterprises of the Hellenic era. Of these, Greek medicine may rank as high as Greek drama, for, in significant respects, the Hippocratic method was as deliberately original as were the literary methods of Sophocles, Aeschylus, and Euripedes. In fact, when we come to examine the biological turn taken by Aristotle's natural philosophy, we must keep in mind the background influences of the Hippocratic school and Greek science in general.

Although the Hippocratics are discussed only fleetingly in the dialogues, the medical scholarship of ancient Greece suffuses Aristotle's naturalistic writings at many points. We observed in the discussion of the pre-Socratics that no rigid boundary divided philosophical and scientific inquiry. Philosophy and physics, morals and cosmology, were but altered aspects of the same underlying *logos*. The Pythagoreans accepted this notion, so much so that their ethics and theology were thoroughly intermingled with geometry. It appears as if the Greek physicians shared this integrated conception of nature. Until the dialectical and speculative elements of philosophy were made dominant by the members of Plato's Academy, and until the "true forms" replaced observable nature as the subject matter of philosophical importance, medicine and philosophy were handmaidens to each other. Platonic idealism, whose central message included skepticism toward the evidence of experience, was less than compatible with both the practice of medicine and those findings uncovered in the medical clinics every day by a host of practitioners.

Hippocrates himself is hard to date. Plato's dialogues make reference to Hippocratics, suggesting that Hippocrates was older than the dialogues. It is customary to assign his floruit to about 400. What we have of his medical treatises

we owe principally to Galen (c. 130–200 A.D.), but the oldest manuscripts available which purport to be translations of Galen's works are by authors living eight centuries after Galen himself.¹⁷ While this renders more difficult the task of authenticating the various treatises attributed to Hippocrates, there is sufficient presumptive evidence from many different sources, including ancient ones, for us to reconstruct the essential character of the Hippocratic theory and overall approach.

The approach is uncompromisingly empirical. As philosophy became more speculative, the Hellenic physicians may have become ever less interested in philosophers' notions about health and disease. What survived of philosophy in Greek medicine were remnants of Pythagoreanism, which treated disease of any sort as a lack of harmony. Hippocrates and the famous oath that bears his name may well have substantial debts to Pythagorean teaching. As practical biologists, the followers of Hippocrates reasoned that the body itself, and especially the humors of the body, required a delicate and harmonious balance. It was not uncommon for delirium and fits to be treated through the combination of specific foods and music. Diet was especially integral to therapy. In the Hippocratic works on *Epidemics* there is frequent reference to fever and cold, to "fluxes" or storms of the humours. Similarly, remedies focus on sleep and rest, quietude and temperance. In the next chapter, we will see that Aristotle's theories of memory and perception also take recourse to the notion of restlessness or quietude of the mind and the perceiving faculties. But more important than the specific observations made by the Hippocratics was their commitment to observation. Greek medicine was quite advanced. It served as a constant reminder that the world of sense and the empirical method of fact-gathering were suspended only at the peril of those who wished to learn and understand.

Hippocrates (or whoever is responsible for the teachings attributed to him) had recorded the fact that injuries to either side of the head resulted in spasms on the contralateral side.¹⁸ There are also Hippocratic treatises on the venous supply to the brain and a nearly modern respect for the role of this organ in perception, movement, and any number of psychological processes and functions. The Hippocratic *Humoural* theory of psychological dispositions accorded an unchangeably phlegmatic nature to some (and therefore to their children!), a bilious one to another, a choleric to yet another. The justification for such attributions was not rigorously empirical but was surely based on family resemblances in the matter of temperament. Indirectly, such a genetic type-theory of personality lent support to the eugenic theories of Plato's Academy. Still, in the main, Hippocrates and his followers come close to the modern spirit of experimental science and clinical observation. They specifically rejected that Platonic version of "hypothesis" according to which all discourse must begin with self-evident truths, regarding such hypotheses as antithetical to the good care of patients and an understanding of their diseases. In the place of these the

Hippocratics compiled a veritable handbook of symptoms, therapies, and results. In the process, and through the translations and the influence of Galen, they had an effect on the practice and theory of medicine for over two thousand years. More subtly but just as surely, they required of any psychological philosophy that it address itself to the biological facts of human life and to the relationship between those facts and any theory that might be advanced to explain a psychological process.

Résumé

The Socratic philosophers, whose achievements were immortalized and “rejuvenated” by Plato, advanced many of the central problems with which all subsequent psychological scholarship would have to contend. They insisted on a distinction between the factual knowledge gleaned by error-prone perception and that knowledge of general principles made possible by reason alone. Combined with this was the assertion that knowledge, properly understood, is a recollection of that which is implanted within the soul (mind) natively. These theories have modern counterparts in the form of theories of cognition and genetic theories of intellect and emotion. The Socratics, to a far greater extent than one finds in contemporary psychology, emphasized the part played by the political and moral dimensions of the State in forging the character of the young. Their recognition of the interdependence of politics, morality, art, and psychology awaits recovery. Coeval with the development of idealistic philosophies was the development of Greek medicine along rigorously practical and observational lines.

Notes

1. On the Greek religious attitude, consult W. K. C. Guthrie's fine study, *The Greeks and Their Gods*, Beacon Press, Boston, 1950. My interpretation is not, however, identical to Professor Guthrie's.

2. On the influence of Miletus, consult Herodotus, Book I, 17–22; and Book V, 23–25. See also *The Cambridge Ancient History*, edited by J. S. Bury et al., Macmillan, New York, 1926, pp. 87–97; James Henry Breasted, *A History of Egypt*, Charles Scribner's Sons, New York, 1912; and Kathleen Freeman, *Ancilla to the Pre-Socratic Philosophers*, Basil Blackwell, Oxford, 1952.

3. Plutarch, *The Lives of the Noble Grecians and Romans*, translated by John Dryden, 1864 ed.; reprinted by Random House, New York, 1932. Xenophon's *Memorabilia* includes a sketch of Socrates that is important for corroborative purposes. It was written at least thirty years after the death of Socrates.

4. The Second Epistle, from which the quotation is taken, is of questionable authenticity. But the very same modesty is expressed in the Seventh Epistle (Sec. 341) whose authenticity is well established. In translating the Second Epistle, we may substitute “idealized” for “embellished.” On this reading Plato may be admitting that he did more than merely adorn the teachings of Socrates.

5. For the collection of Plato's *Epistles*, consult Glen R. Morrow, *Plato's Epistles*, Bobbs-Merrill, Indianapolis, 1962.

6. The edition of the dialogues used in the present work is *The Dialogues of Plato*, 2 vols., translated by Benjamin Jowett. Random House, New York, 1937. Here and following, however, the parenthetical page numbers refer to the standard Greek manuscript by Stephens.

7. Ibid.

8. Ibid.

9. Ibid.

10. Bertrand Russell, *A History of Western Philosophy*, 14th ed., Simon and Schuster, New York (first printing, 1945). See especially pp. 10–105.

11. *The Dialogues of Plato*, p. 874. The reader will gain useful insights into Platonic philosophy by reading Professor Jowett's Index. The Index is not merely an alphabetical list of terms but is, in addition, an analysis of the meaning of the terms in context.

12. Ibid.

13. Ibid.

14. Ibid.

15. Bertrand Russell, *A History of Western Philosophy*, p. 105.

16. See, for example, *America: 1938–1944*, Vol. II of *The Autobiography of Bertrand Russell*, Atlantic Monthly Press, Little, Brown, Boston, 1968. Lord Russell confronted an intellectual intolerance quite as severe as we might have found in the Athens of Pericles.

17. The authoritative edition of the Hippocratic system is the translation by W. H. S. Jones, *Hippocrates*, 3 vols., Putnam, New York, 1923. Professor Jones's introduction is most useful.

3

The Hellenistic Age: Aristotle, the Epicureans, and the Stoics

Aristotle (385–322): His Philosophical Development

Vico's warning against the glorification of antiquity tends to fall on deaf ears when the full sweep of Aristotle's achievement presents itself. Here is a philosopher-scientist who has had a more direct and enduring effect on more departments of scholarship than any other single figure. More than one reverent historian has described him as the last person to have known everything that was known in his own time.

What we know of his life is spotty. He was a devoted student of Plato's for some twenty years, perhaps from the founding of the Academy (367 B.C.) until the master's death (347), although he participates in only one of the dialogues, the *Parmenides*. He was born in Stageirus, on the eastern edge of the Chalcidice, and was of Ionian heritage. His father was personal physician to the Macedonian king, Amyntas II, father of Philip II and grandfather of Alexander the Great. Thus, a measure of the prestige enjoyed by the Academy can be gleaned from the fact that a family of means and connections would send their seventeen-year-old son there for instruction.

Following Werner Jaeger, it is customary to separate Aristotle's philosophical development into three stages.¹ In the first, he is a Platonist to the core, the author of now lost dialogues, the student of the "ideas." The next phase of his life comes when the direction of the Academy falls to Plato's cousin, Speusippus, in 347. This was either the cause or a mere coincidence attending Aristotle's departure from Athens. During the following twelve years (347–335), his busy life included his marriage to Pythias, his teaching of Alexander (334–336), his direction of the group of Platonists at Assos, and what must have been a reassessment of his own position on basic philosophical and scientific questions. The third phase begins with the death of Philip II and the accession to power of Alexander (335). Now Aristotle returns to Athens, establishes his